FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

When the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam was passed unanimously in September 2023, it was hailed as a revolution in gender empowerment. It fulfilled the old dream to reserve 33 per cent of Lok Sabha seats for women. So, when the Modi government called a special session of Parliament to fast-track its implementation through the 131st Amendment, it was a worthy display of legislative resolve that was expected to meet no resistance. Under it, the Lok Sabha would be expanded from 543 to 850 seats to accommodate a one-third quota without reducing anyone's share. The new constituencies would be determined through delimitation. Instead of waiting for the 2027 Census to facilitate this, as the Nari Shakti Act had provided, the amendment proposed using the latest available Census (2011, in this case) to ensure women's reservation in the 2029 general election, rather than 2034, as earlier envisaged. The amendment's intent was unimpeachable. It is a concrete act of democratic correction in a legislature where women currently occupy only 13.6 per cent of seats, one of the lowest ratios among major democracies.

For the Opposition, the red flag was delimitation, in which constituency boundaries are redrawn. It feared the process would give the ruling party an advantage. With this timeline, the question of caste that would come up after the new Census, which offers the first OBC data update since 1931, would also be avoided. The Opposition's resistance effectively killed the bill, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi even compared it to "foeticide". Seemingly technical questions had become a political minefield.



▲ Oct. 2, 2023

Significant among them is the apprehension that a population-based formula would amplify the political weight of the northern states at the South's expense. This despite Union home minister Amit Shah pointing out in Parliament that the five southern states stood to gain 19 more seats under the 50 per cent formula when compared to applying the 2011 census as the basis. The Opposition's concerns are not without precedent. India has twice deferred delimitation, under Indira Gandhi in 1976, and by A.B. Vajpayee in 2001, precisely to avoid penalising states that succeeded in controlling population growth. The current proposal risks reopening that settled compromise without adequate safeguards. There is also the unresolved question of representation within representation. Any meaningful expansion of women's participation will inevitably raise demands for sub-quotas, particularly for OBC women, once updated caste data becomes available. What began as a straightforward measure for gender equity has thus become entangled in the larger, more contentious debate over federal balance and social justice.

Yet the urgency of the objective cannot be denied. Women remain significantly under-represented in Parliament, and incremental change has proved insufficient. The Opposition's suggestion to reserve one-third of the existing 543 seats offers a simpler, immediate pathway. It avoids the complications of Census timelines and delimitation exercises. But it raises its own political challenges. Deciding which constituencies to reserve, and which incumbents to displace, is not merely a technical question. It strikes at the core of political self-interest across parties.

The government's counter-argument is that expansion offers a cleaner solution. A larger House would accommodate women without reducing existing stakes. It also aligns with a long-standing democratic principle that representation must reflect population realities. Today, the disparity is stark. An MP from a densely populated constituency represents a few million voters, while another from a smaller region represents a fraction of that number. Such imbalances undermine the very idea of equal representation.

The difficulty lies in reconciling these competing imperatives. Any attempt to correct representational inequities must not come at the cost of widening regional distrust. Nor can gender justice be held hostage to unresolved political questions. The way forward, therefore, lies not in a single sweeping solution, but in sequencing and consensus.

The first priority must be the timely and credible completion of the 2027 Census. Without reliable data, any delimitation exercise will lack legitimacy. It should be followed by the constitution of a Delimitation Commission whose composition commands bipartisan trust. Only then can the process avoid the suspicion of political manipulation. Parallelly, a broad agreement is needed on how to operationalise women's reservation without subsuming it into other debates. Whether through phased implementation or interim arrangements, the objective should be to ensure that the reform does not drift indefinitely.

In this week's cover story, Managing Editor Kaushik Deka and Senior Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan map every dimension of this impasse, consulting politicians, bureaucrats, social scientists and legal scholars across the spectrum. Their analysis makes one conclusion unavoidable. The arithmetic of power in the Lok Sabha has opened a Pandora's box. But Pandora's box, as the myth reminds us, also contained hope. The time for sequencing, consensus and political courage is now. Not 2034.

India's democratic strength has always rested on its ability to accommodate complexity without losing direction. Women's reservation is not merely a legislative adjustment. It is a test of that capacity. A nation that seeks to harness the full potential of its people cannot afford to let half its population remain on the margins of political power.

(Aroon Purie)